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*THE HARPSICHORD: ITS PRESENT AND ITS
FUTURE.*

BY C. VERE PILKINGTON, B.A.

MUSIC is nothing if it is not alive. I happen to have chosen the harpsichord as my instrument—or it has chosen me, I am never quite sure which—and in consequence to have made a special study of the fine and extensive range of music written for it, most of which is largely incomprehensible if played on another instrument. But the music written now must have a far more vital importance for those who are alive to-day than what is after all “museum” music; therefore I have chosen to speak of the Present and Future of the Harpsichord rather than of its past.

The instrument I am using to illustrate this paper was made by Gaveau, of Paris, in 1923 to the specifications of Arnold Dolmetsch, modelled on one of J. S. Bach's latest harpsichords, but with pedals instead of hand stops.

I have tried to keep this paper as simple and compact as I can; so I hope you will forgive me if I remind you in the course of it of things you may already know.

The harpsichord, particularly during the eighteenth century, formed an essential part of almost any music-making. Apart from the organ its only keyboard rival was the clavichord which has such a small tone, lovely though it is, that it can hardly be played with any other instrument. So the harpsichord was used as a solo instrument, as a concerto instrument, for accompanying, and for filling in the harmonies and giving “attack” in orchestral music. Conductors generally conducted from one harpsichord which very often was supported by another particularly in *concerti grossi*.

The harpsichord seems to have filled all these functions admirably and we hear no complaints of it. But suddenly at the end of the eighteenth century the pianoforte in a form very different from the pianoforte of to-day suddenly leapt into favour sponsored in this country by John Christian Bach, Clementi and Field; and in a few years time when Moscheles

came to England he was unable to find in London a single harpsichord in first-rate playing condition. This extraordinarily abrupt change was largely due to the great similarity in tone between the harpsichord and the early pianoforte. Players thought they were using merely an improved kind of harpsichord ; but by the time they had forgotten the harpsichord the pianoforte had turned into quite another sort of instrument bearing little resemblance in tone to the pianoforte of 1790.

During the entire nineteenth century the want of the harpsichord does not seem to have become felt. Audiences must have been so stunned by the virtuosity of the new generation of pianists and the increase of tone of almost every instrument in the orchestra that mere quality of tone was hardly considered if volume had to be sacrificed to get it. And I have always thought that the pre-occupation of nineteenth and late eighteenth century music with the *appoggiatura*, for which the pianoforte offered exceptional facilities, may have been an important factor in the neglect of the harpsichord.

After a lapse of nearly a hundred years the work of such scholars as Barclay Squire, Fuller-Maitland, Hopkins and Arnold Dolmetsch revived an interest in the harpsichord, but almost entirely from an antiquarian standpoint. It is only during the last fifteen years or so that the harpsichord has again been considered as an instrument in its own right. Now works have been written for the harpsichord by de Falla, Poulenc, Delius and other present-day composers ; conductors are beginning to realise how futile it is to play eighteenth century music without using the harpsichord ; there are several firms in existence such as Pleyel, Gaveau and Neupert who manufacture harpsichords ; and one can hardly make a rapid tour of the European Broadcasting Stations of an evening without finding a harpsichord in use at one or more of them.

Such a revival must mean that there is a real need for the harpsichord nowadays ; but in the lapse of time since the eighteenth century musicians have forgotten exactly what are the qualities of a harpsichord and how music should be written for it. And they must consider if with the mechanical advance of this age any improvements can be made in the mechanism of the instrument.

I think my best way to explain what are the principal resources of the harpsichord, is to contrast the pianoforte with it. In principle I dislike doing this as the two are such

totally different instruments ; but as one has for a hundred years or more usurped the functions of the other, I believe that the advantages of the harpsichord are more clearly brought home in this way than in any other.

I believe that you will all agree with me that the bases of all music are line, colour and rhythm. Let us see how these two keyboard instruments respond to their requirements.

All music is in origin vocal and a singing tone is necessary to music ; in fact, one may go so far as to say that one can never become sincerely attached to a piece of music which one cannot sing all through to oneself. If you asked most musicians whether the harpsichord or the pianoforte gives the finest *cantabile* line they would say " the pianoforte " without thinking ; but I believe that the harpsichord can give a far closer and smoother *legato*. The actual hammer-blow on the wires of the pianoforte, a music-less mechanical thud to which we have unthinkingly accustomed ourselves, is sufficient to destroy all possibility of a perfect *legato*. But the click of the harpsichord action, when properly played and in proper order, is hardly audible and a stream of *legato* far more closely woven and liquid is obtainable than on the pianoforte. This *legato* is one of the chief glories of the harpsichord and one of the few records we have of J. S. Bach's teaching mentions his insistence to his pupils on the *cantabile* in their harpsichord playing.

The colour range of the piano is in some ways more limited than that of the harpsichord. It has always seemed to me that colour in music to be effective must not be treated by a constant shifting of shades but by a definite clear change from one tint to another. A constant gradation which is not from one definite colour to another merely becomes monotonous, since the ear has no definite standard from which or to which the colour-scheme is shifting. On the piano it is extremely difficult to make and to maintain any one clear colour. Of even the very greatest piano virtuosi there are only very few like Horowitz who can produce and maintain two or three different colours at the same time and then change them completely to other colours when the music requires it. The harpsichord has a very large number of quite definite colours, which can nowadays be shaded with the use of the pedal, but which are there as definite standards so that the ear when once accustomed to the sonorities can easily appreciate and be refreshed by the inter-play of clear cut changes of colour. It is of course true that the pianoforte has the great advantage over the harpsichord that any one note in a chord can be made to stand out by a variation of

touch, but it is also true to say that notes can be made to stand out by very slight variations in rhythm giving the effect of a "false" accent, or by the careful use of texture or ornament. I think it is possible to claim justly that the harpsichord has a far greater range of colours than the piano and that its tone is far clearer and less overloaded with confusing overtones.

The clarity and neatness of harpsichord tone allows of extremely subtle and varied uses of rhythm. The muddy tones of the pianoforte on the contrary make really precise timing difficult and often ineffectual. It may be my imagination but I believe that owing to the much greater simplicity of the harpsichord action a far greater tautness of rhythm is obtainable than can ever be on the piano ; certainly, constant playing on the harpsichord gives an awareness of rhythm and a knowledge of its possibilities which rarely seem to be realised by piano players. The minute variations from a fundamentally steady rhythm, the sudden cutting off of a note or the early or delayed attack on it have in so many cases an effect of far more intrinsically musical value than the mere dynamic action of hitting a note harder to accentuate it, which often completely puts the note out of scale and colour with the phrase in which it is, and so spoils the flow of the line.

The pianoforte for a number of years now seems to have lost further power of development. It may be that the pianoforte has come to be considered such a standard instrument that it is incapable of further progress, though I think you will all agree, that the colour possibilities and the damping of the piano too, should be further improved.

The harpsichord, although in its modern and revised form it has been improved in several ways, has in essentials progressed very little from the instrument of the late eighteenth century, and needs to be improved not only on the lines of the Pleyel and Gaveau harpsichords by a multiplication of pedals as a substitute for hand-stops, but by a complete revision in the light of modern mechanics. I shall hope to show that there are great possibilities for improvement of the harpsichord, which would inevitably lead to its more general use.

The first need is to make the harpsichord as fool-proof as the modern piano. The first drawback that conductors will allege against the harpsichord is that it is very liable to go out of tune very rapidly with changes of temperature, so that its use in Concert Halls and Theatres is sometimes difficult. One of the chief reasons for its going out of tune is the much greater range of the wires in length and thickness than that of the piano. When you have wires that have to sound an octave

above and below normal, as well as the unison strings at the ordinary pitch, in a frame smaller than that of a grand piano, the most accurate scaling is needed so that no string shall be under excessive tension. There are two other factors which I believe also contribute to the liability to go out of tune ; firstly, the lack of a skeleton iron frame which, as is shown in the modern Pleyel, can be introduced into the body of the harpsichord without seriously altering the tone, and secondly, the eighteenth-century legacy of small tuning-pins. A light metal frame, even more successful than that of the Pleyel, could be constructed, of one of the numerous modern metal alloys, which would in no way alter the tone of the harpsichord but would prevent the belly from shifting, even microscopically ; and if tuning-pins, of the size used on the modern piano, were introduced there would be much less likelihood of the pegs shifting in the tuning board owing to changes of temperature. The only occasion I know in which piano pins were used was on a mid-eighteenth century spinet which remained in tune under severe changes of temperature far longer than any other instrument of its kind I remember.

In order to make the harpsichord more useful in general, and in particular as a transcription instrument, a damper-lifting pedal or even two (one for each keyboard) could easily be introduced and has in fact been fitted by Mr. Arnold Dolmetsch on his more recent instruments. I should suggest also that the keyboards should be bevelled into one another, as in the case of modern organ manuals. Research should be carried out on the most suitable material of which to make the actual pluckers. Even the hardest leather, or the most carefully cut quill, does not last at its finest for very long, but there are so many modern materials such as the synthetic horn which is used at the bottom of a golf driver club, or some metal alloy even, which might give very much improved results. The whole action should be revised ; the racks on which the jacks are carried should be made of some light metal to prevent expansion and sticking in wet weather, and the jacks themselves need to be radically altered. It should be possible to construct a simple action by which the jacks instead of touching the strings with their pluckers on the return when the key is released, should automatically return on an incline so avoiding the minute click that is inevitable with the present action. I have also proposed a register of infinitely variable tone on one manual, though certain harpsichord builders have advised me that they believe this impossible. My suggestion was based on the fact that the tone of the string varies according to the distance from the bridge at which it is

plucked. If, therefore, the jacks were constructed on a rack which could be moved by a pedal to and from the bridge as many variations of tone could be produced as a guitar is capable of in the hands of a master like Segovia.

I now come to the section of my paper which I regard as the most important because it attacks a subject which so far as I know has never before been attempted, and because I regard the harpsichord just as much as an instrument of the future as an instrument of the past.

I propose in this section to give advice to composers how to write for the instrument. I shall divide it into three headings : first, Texture ; second, Rhythm ; and thirdly, Colour.

Firstly, *Texture*. It is important to remember that with the existing instrument it is essential to write only notes which can be played by the hands without the assistance of any holding pedal, and it is worth noticing that the music which sounds best lies under the hands when they are closest together. Whatever Texture one adopts, whether single counterpoint or the fullest harmonic counterpoint, notes which occur at each end of the keyboard should be generally avoided except when staccato notes are used as a bass or as punctuation in the treble in the Scarlattian fashion, or where an emphatic scale starts from the bass and runs into the centre of the keyboard. The extremities of the keyboard should be reserved for special effects when only a single solo part is required or when both hands lie close together in figuration. With these limitations any texture, however thin or however thick, is permissible. We may use simple two-part counterpoint, effectively crossing on the two keyboards or we may use the thickest possible harmonies that can be grasped by the hands, not excluding common chords with thirds and fifths in the bass. On the one hand we may take as an example Couperin's *Tic-Toc*.

And on the other the opening of a *Saraband* by Lennox Berkeley.

[*Musical Illustration.*]

No harmonic scheme is too thick or complicated to be readily comprehended by the ear when played on the harpsichord. It is for example perfectly possible to combine the major chords of C and C#, so that the ear will agreeably hear and understand the combination. And it is in this last direction perhaps that there lies one of the most interesting possibilities for modern composers.

On the other hand simple flowing lines in two-part counterpoint of which the phrases fall so naturally into place that hardly any effects of staccato or of accent are needed to make their cæsuras easily comprehensible, tell with an effect of *legato* which is unobtainable on the pianoforte ; and the interplay of the parts can be deliciously varied with the range of colours available.

What should be avoided is the effect so common in nineteenth-century music of a melody and a bass with vague figuration in between, such as one finds in the work of Schumann or of César Franck. A most agreeable effect may be obtained by the gradual addition of strands so common in Bach, of which the fugue which is the last movement of the C major *Concerto* for two harpsichords provides an excellent example.

[*Musical Illustration.*]

In thickening the texture, each of the parts should have a clear cut rhythmic scheme, as for example where two outside parts run at half or quarter speed of that of the interior part.

When you wish to bring out a melody over a harmonic scheme there are several methods to adopt. The first is used by Handel in the *Adagio* which begins the Second Suite, where a melody, decorated in the rococo manner which is so suitable to the harpsichord, flows over a rhythmically steady harmonic accompaniment of two parts in the centre of the keyboard. (*Example.*) Another is when a swiftly running tune is supported by a rhythmic accompaniment which might have been taken from the guitar as in Scarlatti's Sonata No. 257, as I shall show later. Another, where snatches of melody punctuated by a bass are heard above and below a central running part as in the F minor *Allegro* of C. P. E. Bach, both melody and bass being played by the left hand.

[*Musical Illustration.*]

Another is where the melody both by its superior position and its strong rhythmic scheme stands out by itself as in the *Saraband* by Chambonnières (No. 120 in the Collected Edition).

[*Musical Illustration.*]

When you wish to treat a melody above a slow moving bass with a harmonic core, both the bass and the harmonic core must be slow moving and with an easily understood

rhythmic scheme which allows of rubato in the interpretation of the melody, as in the *Allemande* in Bach's fourth Partita.

[*Musical Illustration.*]

In slow movements where a recitative-like melody seems effective its course may be punctuated by heavy chords as in the fourth movement of the Purcell *Toccata*. (*Example.*)

Octaves should be used only with great discretion, particularly in the treble. For some reason they do not, as in the common usage of pianoforte writing, strengthen a melodic part ; and in all the works of Bach, Handel and Scarlatti you will hardly find a single use of them, except rarely in Scarlatti where they are used principally for two effects, either a bell-like punctuation, or for rapid dry passages imitating the sounds of hunting horns, as in the F minor Sonata, No. 475. In the bass they sound very strong and produce a fine effect, particularly with the addition of the fifth of which a magnificent instance is the long passage on a pedal at the end of the third movement of the Purcell *Toccata*. (*Example.*) Apart from their use as a pedal (where they are repeated) they were used by the older composers almost always in dry staccato effects ; when a strong *legato* passage was needed in the bass they were alternated with single notes so as to assist the left hand in making a perfect *legato*. Broken octaves are extremely effective throughout the keyboard.

The staccato should also be used carefully since it has a far drier and more explosive effect than on the piano, and except when heavy staccato chords are used for punctuation it is most effective in a continuous passage rather than in isolated groups of notes.

Rhythm is not only probably the earliest basis of music, but provides the harpsichord with its greatest and subtlest effects. Every piece written for the harpsichord must have a clear rhythmic scheme. However many are the parts, their rhythms, if only of two bars' length as is so common with Scarlatti, must be definite and clear. As I have said above, the harmonic scheme may be infinitely complicated provided that the rhythmic structure is easily comprehensible. For instance, the preludes to so many of Bach's Suites make their great effect on rhythmic lines. Take as an example the Prelude to the third *English Suite* where over a steady beat of three which never wavers throughout the entire movement the greatest possible play is made with the thickening and thinning of texture.

Rhythm on the harpsichord may be continuous, or infinitely varied as in the Scarlatti *Sonata*, No. 257¹, which provides an example of almost every point I have already talked about.

[*Musical Example.*]

You will see that most startling effects of rhythm are produced in two ways, either by the sudden interruption of one or all parts, or by a sudden thickening of texture which produces the effect of a *sforzando*.

On the harpsichord Accents are obtained in two ways, by the sudden increase in texture, or more constantly and more effectively by minute variations in the rhythm ; to take an example, in order to accentuate the first note of an *appoggiatura* it is necessary to take the preceding note off short ; and this will be found to give just as much effect as the pianoforte method of playing the second of the two notes of the *appoggiatura* more softly. Such methods of taking off a note short and attacking another one late or early to emphasise its importance are so much the common property of all music (though too often disregarded) that I do not propose to talk of them at greater length.

For the further study of rhythmic effects on the harpsichord there are two lengthy but almost final examples, namely, Bach's *Goldberg Variations* and the entire works of Scarlatti.

To describe *Colour* in words is peculiarly difficult. I shall, however, attempt to explain the primary colours of the harpsichord and their more simple combinations. All harpsichords with a full complement of stops have two sets of unison strings, the one slightly more brilliant in tone than the other so that one can be used against the other as solo against accompaniment. The addition of the four-foot tone to the less brilliant will reverse the position so that the more brilliant unison, which is almost invariably on the upper manual can then be used as accompaniment. Alternatively, with the full complement of stops coupled on the lower manual the upper manual can be used as an echo of the lower.

It should always be borne in mind that the difference in the actual volume of tone produced by the harpsichord, whether a single unison is used or the full complement of stops, is very small and that the difference is almost entirely a question of colour, that is, that one tone is rounder, richer, or drier than another. It is not advisable to use a four-foot,

¹ Longo Edition (Ricordi, Milano).

eight-foot and sixteen-foot stop together as a solo combination, but there is very beautiful tone-quality which has a faint resemblance to harp harmonics which can be obtained by using the four-foot and sixteen-foot together without the eight-foot. For an effect of great brilliance the four-foot stop alone can be used played an octave lower; and for a curiously bell-like tone the sixteen-foot register alone at the top of the keyboard.

Some harpsichords have a stop known as the *lute*, which is an alternative register of the upper keyboard and which produces a rather nasal reedy tone which is comparable to oboe tone.

All instruments have a *buff* or harp-stop which acting on either or both of the unisons produces a delicious, delicate *pizzicato*; where this is used the unisons should not be coupled either with each other or with any other stop, though the unisons may be left to contrast with each other, or one unison with a harp stop may be used as a quasi-guitar accompaniment to the other. A number of trick effects can be produced by using the various stops at half strength; and a very curious organ-like effect may be produced by letting up the *pizzicato* pedal the instant a chord has been struck; but this can only be used in slow passages.

If chords are very slightly broken and rolled up and down a much richer and less accented sound is heard than when all the notes of the chord are struck exactly together. This effect has been very well exploited by de Falla in his Harpsichord Concerto. Chords which are continuously rolled up and down in the effect referred to by the old masters as "*arpeggiando*" make a beautifully rich sound of which an outstanding example is Bach's alternative Prelude to the *English Suite*.

[*Musical Illustration.*]

To change colours too constantly is a trap for the novice. The ear should be allowed to become accustomed to one colour before a change to the next.

* * *

I should like to end this paper by saying a few words about the use of the harpsichord in combination with other instruments.

In the harpsichord concerto, composers should beware of overloading the orchestration. The harpsichord sounds at its best with a small body of strings, perhaps without double

bass, and with a few wood-wind instruments from which the clarinet should be preferably excluded. Light and varied percussion may be added. The harpsichord blends so well with other instruments that it is not easily heard through any thick orchestral texture, though it can add enormously to brilliance of quality, and above all to attack. The harpsichord, therefore, should be allowed its most significant passages, either to itself, accompanied only by a string bass, or with very light counterpoint from a solo instrument, or as in the de Falla Concerto punctuated by wood-wind adding small flecks of colour. The addition of another one or two harpsichords to a score increases the volume of harpsichord tone strangely little, but adds enormously to the enrichment and brilliance of colour. Harpsichord and strings alone are an extremely effective combination; here as before the harpsichord enriches the tone and adds enormously to the attack of the strings. In a solo passage alternating with strings the harpsichord tone makes a refreshing change without making such a violent break with string tone as does the pianoforte.

The balance of tone between a solo stringed instrument or bassoon, oboe or flute, and the piano, has always been a major problem for composers. The harpsichord, though at present a little deficient in tone, is still far the most suitable accompanying instrument for a solo sonata. With the violoncello the harpsichord is at its best, and as to my mind the problem of balance between violoncello and piano has never been successfully solved, I recommend that the very limited violoncello repertoire should be quickly increased by some 'cello and harpsichord sonatas. In contrapuntal movements the lines of harpsichord and 'cello flow side by side or intermingle perfectly; in slow movements the melody of the 'cello against thick rich moving harmonies sounds extraordinarily lovely. But I should give a warning against the use of the accompanying figure so prevalent in sonatas with the piano, namely, a string of repeated chords. In slow movements where a modern transcriber would use repeated harmonies for a pianoforte part, it is always advisable to substitute broken figuration for the harpsichord.

I hope to see the use of the harpsichord in chamber orchestras revived; as the sharpness of attack which it is able to give can hardly be produced by any other means. I also hope to hear the harpsichord one day in a jazz band, for I believe that its quality of tone, its sharpness and dryness would supply a real want in jazz orchestration, and might add enormously to the possibilities of modulation, the lack of which is so noticeable in jazz and tango writing.

All I have said to-day applies to the harpsichord as it is at present ; it is my greatest hope that someone with the means at his command will experiment on the lines I have suggested and by making the instrument foolproof and increasing its power, assist in the revival which seems so clearly indicated to-day.

DISCUSSION.

THE CHAIRMAN : That has been a delightful paper, ladies and gentlemen. We must thank Mr. Pilkington warmly. I only wish it were possible to convey the musical illustrations in the *Proceedings*, particularly at a lecture of this kind where the presence of the harpsichord and the excellent playing are so much a part of the lecturer's case.

I should like to mention one or two difficulties ; but I want to say at the outset that I am entirely sympathetic with the lecturer's point of view. Indeed, if he will forgive me for touching on a personal matter, I carry on my finger the signet-ring of my great-great-grandfather, who was none other than Shudi the harpsichord maker himself ! I have given some amount of thought to the question of the harpsichord and its possible resuscitation. The story of the development of musical instruments is very much the story of the evolution of species according to Darwin : the stronger and more adaptable instrument outgrows, swamps and in the end exterminates the weaker. Such, I fear has been the story of the pianoforte and the harpsichord. Mr. Pilkington told us, I think, that the pianoforte and the harpsichord started off all square. But let us take the present-day position in regard to volume of sound. We must all have noticed that the illustrations which were the pleasantest to listen to were the longest ones. They received the most applause and I should like to suggest the reason for the greater appeal that they made. Now when Mr. Pilkington spoke, our ears recognised the level of the usual human talking-voice. When he played the harpsichord, our ears eased themselves down to the level of that delightful instrument. The longer he played, the better our hearing accommodated itself. *But*, when he spoke again, we thought to ourselves : "What a loud speaking voice the lecturer has !" In the longer illustrations our ears had time to acclimatise themselves comfortably to full enjoyment of the harpsichord's delicate and elegant tones. In short, one of its deficiencies is its small volume of tone.

Can we somehow find means of getting sufficient power ? When that is done the harpsichord will stand a good chance

of competing with the pianoforte. As it is, it is difficult to make the harpsichord "come over" satisfactorily in a theatre or a concert hall.

Mr. PILKINGTON : I have played in Queen's Hall and been heard through the orchestra quite easily in the gallery.

The CHAIRMAN : People with good ears would be able to hear ; but I well remember that it was in the Queen's Hall that I attended a concert with a friend who complained that he could not hear a single note that the harpsichord was playing.

A second difficulty in the way of the harpsichord's popularity is that of size. In earlier days it was not unusual to find grand pianos seven and eight feet in length in drawing-rooms. The harpsichord could then compete favourably as to size. Nowadays the pianoforte trade has to cater more and more for a market which calls for small grands, such as the "baby" and "miniature-grand" pianos, and recently instruments have been made as short as four feet. There is also a large demand for uprights to-day, because they take up less space. If I point out those two main difficulties, it is only in order that they may be overcome.

On the matter of tone, I may be allowed perhaps to correct our lecturer on one point. It is not quite true to say that the pianoforte of 1790 had the same tone-quality as the harpsichord. By that time they produced quite different sounds. But it would be correct to say that the earliest pianofortes imitated the tone of the harpsichord. The tone as recognised to-day as typical of the piano did not originally exist at all ; it has gradually been evolved. Mr. Pilkington rather suggests perhaps that the pianoforte is not still evolving and has not been for some years past. I can assure him that, with the support of the present generation's increased interest in music, the pianoforte of 1935 is still developing in certain quite important directions. We have means at our disposal to-day that were not available even twenty years ago.

I believe that the harpsichord can be developed too, given sufficient enthusiasm. The harpsichord's habit of going out of tune is only a technical matter, which in these days could quite easily be got over. It arose out of the use of wooden frames ; not only was the wood not rigid, but it was affected by weather conditions and the temperature of a room.

Canon GALPIN : I want to second your vote of thanks to our lecturer. It is a great pleasure for me to hear Mr. Pilkington again. Years ago he came to my house and played

on my little virginal of 1552. It delighted me ; but it is a still greater pleasure to hear his performance on the beautiful harpsichord he has here to-day.

I have had the privilege of playing on early pianos. I played on the oldest Cristofori piano extant in Florence which was made in 1720 ; also on Signor Krauss's specimen of 1726. The former is now in New York, and the latter at Leipzig ; they bear out entirely what the Chairman and Mr. Pilkington have said. They look exactly like harpsichords. They have fine strings, no iron frame and light hammers. One would think that one were touching some sort of quilled instrument. Evidently the first object of the inventor Cristofori in making a piano was to render it as much like a harpsichord as possible, but by 1790 it was beginning to acquire more the piano tone, though I think Mr. Pilkington will agree with me that, when he recently touched a Clementi piano belonging to Mr. Croft Murray, there again was a different tone from the modern piano, a tone more like the harpsichord at that time disappearing.

Has Mr. Pilkington the Venetian swell on the instrument here shown ?

MR. PILKINGTON : No, I do not approve of it, because I think it shuts in the typical ringing tone of the harpsichord.

CANON GALPIN : I was delighted to hear you say that the harpsichord chords should be spread, *arpeggio*-wise. I remember when I was a little boy laughing at old ladies who played hymn-tunes on the piano. I thought what ignorant people they were, but they had learnt the harpsichord style of playing, with spread chords.

Have you ever tried the harpsichord with the organ, Mr. Pilkington ?

MR. PILKINGTON : No. It would be an interesting combination.

CANON GALPIN : A friend of mine once played the violoncello with the organ and found difficulty in keeping the rhythm with the organ as an accompaniment. There was no beat to help him in any way. I was wondering whether the harpsichord and the organ, like the harp and organ combination, might be effective in adding distinctness.

MR. PILKINGTON : They ought to do so, I think. Cassado told me it was quite an extraordinary experience playing the 'cello with the harpsichord, because one can play with a freely running bow.

Canon GALPIN : I think they would be charming together ; I know the viola da gamba and the virginal are.

There was at one time at this Academy a wonderful instrument made by Crang of London in 1745. It was a harpsichord and organ combined. The difficulty was to keep the two in tune. There was a fine two-manual harpsichord, and underneath were the organ pipes. One could play either separately, or put both into action together, provided one did not mind their being at times of differing pitch.

Has the lecturer leather *plectra* on this harpsichord ?

Mr. PILKINGTON : Yes, it is entirely leather. The Kirkman harpsichords are almost all leather.

Canon GALPIN : My Kirkman had all quills.

Mr. COBBETT : Is this harpsichord by Kirkman ?

Mr. PILKINGTON : No, it is by Gaveau, of Paris.

Canon GALPIN : To overcome the difficulty of space and size could the body not be turned upwards as they used to be ? In the seventeenth and eighteenth centuries there were upright harpsichords. They were called "Clavicytheriums."

Have you come across an instrument which is masquerading under the name of "harpsichord" and is not one ?

Mr. PILKINGTON : Yes, I have.

Canon GALPIN : It ought not to be called a harpsichord ; it is to be heard sometimes at the B.B.C. recitals. If one puts the back edge of a knife on a tightly stretched string, press it down and then suddenly release it, the string will sound. The very fact that one suddenly releases the pressure makes the string vibrate. There is an instrument on the market which is worked on that principle. On pressing the key a little button rises ; this little button pushes against the string, a spring releases it automatically, and a distinct note results. The string is never plucked, and therefore it ought not to be called a harpsichord.

Mr. PILKINGTON : I would like very strongly to support that, and say that our great national institution should not allow such an instrument to delude people as to the tone quality of a harpsichord.

Canon GALPIN : I would make this suggestion. The harpsichord is called the quill-keyboard instrument (*Kielklavier*) ; the piano is the hammer-keyboard instrument

(*Hammerklavier*). I think that this nondescript production should be called the pressure-keyboard instrument (*Druckklavier*). Do not let it be called the harpsichord because it has no quills or *plectra* of any kind. In French it would appear as the *Poussécorde*.

Mr. HUNT : I notice that on this harpsichord the pedals are all in a row. Would it not be an improvement if they were made on a central piece to radiate, so that the heel is in one position and the foot just twists round ?

Mr. PILKINGTON : I think that in practice the Pleyel pedals that do radiate are much less easy. They are closer together. With the Gaveau the mere fact that you have to move your heel along each time means that you get a central position for the foot against the pedal. Whereas with the Pleyel, which are radiating, you can only touch them with one spot on your foot. I know Madame Landowska makes a point of wearing special slippers which I never have to do.

Mr. HUNT : They radiate outwards from a central position. Would it not be better if they radiated and then turned inwards towards the toes more like the organ pedals ?

Mr. PILKINGTON : One must take into consideration the breadth of the foot. I think it might be managed, but I do not quite see how.

Mr. HUNT : I was rather interested to hear that you do not like the swell.

The other day I noticed, in an article in the *Musical Times* on Dr. Schweitzer, it was said that he did not like the swell and did not use it. I wondered whether that was not a parallel feeling—a feeling that it muffled up the tone, something like the soft pedal of the upright piano (which is different from the key-shifting mechanism of the grand piano).

I have been thinking much about the “ progress ” of instrument-making. In the case of the violin, one has a standardized model ; but mechanical improvements are introduced in it ; modern improvements (stronger bass bar, etc.) to meet modern conditions. Take another case : the organ ; it was a fairly simple instrument. Then came the vogue of very big effects. Now they are, I believe, reverting to something simpler and more musical, particularly on the continent.

The two-manual harpsichords by Kirkman were standardized in four respects : the two eight-foot, the four-foot, and the “ lute ” operating on one of the eight-foot registers.

Mr. PILKINGTON : The harp-stop, too.

Mr. HUNT : The harp-stop is not necessary and does not appear on all Kirkmans. The harp effect can be obtained by leaving the lute-stop "on," and playing on the same series of strings with the keys of the lower manual ; the dampers of the lute-stop jacks then rest on the strings and give the "damped" harp effect.

Mr. PILKINGTON : That I have tried and it can be done, but in actual playing it is likely to lead to confusion ; one forgets which one has left "on."

Mr. HUNT : The point I am trying to make is that, at the time of Kirkman, there was a standardization of a few essential and simple parts. Now as to improvements, do you think it is justifiable to explore further possibilities and "effects" ? For instance, that *vibrato* effect which has been introduced. I, personally, do not like it.

Mr. PILKINGTON : I do not think those are necessary. The harpsichord is good as it is, and to multiply colours would be to do what was done to the nineteenth century organ. But the improvement of a sustaining pedal should be made, because the harpsichord is in many ways suitable as a transcription instrument, and for general use I am sure a sustaining pedal would be of value.

Mr. HUNT : Is not that done on the Pleyels ?

Mr. PILKINGTON : No. The new Dolmetsch harpsichords have a sustaining pedal. No other harpsichord I know of has one.

Mr. HUNT : It has been suggested that, to popularize the harpsichord, the tone should be increased ; also that the size be reduced. I do feel we need a bigger-toned instrument for concert use ; but why not have also a small, simple affair for the home ? For the small one perhaps the harmonium device of providing stops that run only half-way up the keyboard might be used. This might be done by pedals working separately for the upper and lower halves of the keyboard.

Mr. PILKINGTON : You mean that the stops would draw in halves, treble and bass, as the Purcell organ did ? Yes, that is a good idea.

Mr. HOWES : Would a small harpsichord for the home be a commercial proposition ?

Mr. PILKINGTON : It might be. But I think the play of the two manuals at the same pitch is a particularly distinctive feature. It is almost essential to have two manuals on a harpsichord.

Canon GALPIN : I think there might be improvements made on the lines of the old spinet. That was a very useful instrument, and if some stops were added, it would be delightful. The shape, too, was very commodious. I have seen one dating from the eighteenth century at Florence with two registers, and there is one by Cristofori at Leipzig where a second unison string can be brought into action by a lever.

The CHAIRMAN : From the point of view of the harpsichord maker, I feel that every complication added may become an over-complication. One of the factors that militated against the harpsichord in its fight for existence was its terrible elaboration. Some of the differences in tone-colour are so slight and subtle that one is tempted to think that in the interests of simplicity they could have been dispensed with.

Mr. PILKINGTON : I find the question of volume of tone an extraordinarily difficult one, which I have never quite been able to decide for myself. My own harpsichord has been played in almost every concert-hall in London except the Albert Hall. I have played it in the Queen's Hall. A friend of mine who has not particularly good hearing was sitting at the top of the balcony and he told me it came through the orchestra perfectly. I know it will traverse the entire length of St. Paul's Cathedral because it was used for the *St. Matthew Passion*, and I stood by the great doors, and heard it distinctly, although one did not get the full colour. Listening to it with the 'cello, for example, at first one hears very little of the harpsichord, but later on it sounds loud, yet the 'cello does not seem to have become softer. I think this is because the tone-colour is to our ears an unaccustomed one. Even I myself, who am accustomed to it, when I listen to someone playing even solo in a room, often take five minutes really to hear what they are doing ; the sound seems to increase in volume all the time. It must be a question of the unaccustomed quality rather than of actual volume.

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A vote of thanks from the chair to the lecturer was heartily responded to by the audience.